



Presented By:
Gurkhali FC



OFFICIAL 7-A-SIDE FOOTBALL RULEBOOK

1. Competition Identity & Purpose

ABOUT THE COMPETITION

The Grace Dashain Cup is a community-focused 7-a-side football competition presented in the spirit of sporting excellence, inclusion and respect. These regulations establish a clear and consistent framework for teams, players, officials and organisers.

1.1 What this rulebook covers

- Match conditions, playing requirements and restart procedures.
- Squad registration, player eligibility and the competition's Premier Player limit.
- Equipment, substitutions, goalkeeper restrictions and disciplinary procedures.
- Forfeits, late arrival, interruptions, protests and other competition administration.
- The responsibilities of teams, match officials and the competition committee.

1.2 Authority of the competition committee

- The competition committee is responsible for administering these regulations and resolving matters not expressly covered.
- The committee may issue reasonable directions to protect safety, fairness and the orderly conduct of the tournament.
- Where a rule is unclear, the committee's interpretation shall apply for the purposes of the competition.

GUIDING PRINCIPLE

The rules are designed to keep the tournament competitive while protecting player safety and the integrity of the competition.

2. Match-Day Snapshot

Item	Competition Standard
Format	7-a-side
Players on field	6 outfield + 1 goalkeepers
Minimum to start/continue	5 players
Maximum registered for a match	11 players
Rolling substitutes	Up to 3 substitutes at one time
Ball	Size 5
League match	10 minutes each half / 20 minutes total
Finals	15 minutes each half / 30 minutes total
Offside	Not used
Yellow card	5-minute temporary dismissal
Red card	Dismissal for remainder of match + 1-match suspension
Standard forfeit	3–0

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QUICK REFERENCE

All teams should ensure their players understand the eligibility, discipline and goalkeeper provisions before the first match. Ignorance of a competition rule does not remove responsibility for complying with it.

3. Playing Area, Goals & Ball

3.1 Pitch layout

- Matches will be played on a rectangular field suitable for 7-a-side football and smaller than a full-size association football pitch.
- The playing area will be clearly marked with a halfway line and centre mark.
- A defined penalty area and goal area shall be provided at each end.
- Corner areas shall be marked so that corner kicks can be taken from the appropriate location.
- The final pitch dimensions and markings may be adjusted by the organisers to suit the approved venue, provided the field remains safe and appropriate for 7-a-side play.

3.2 Goals

- Goals shall be appropriate for 7-a-side football and smaller than standard full-size football goals.
- Goals and nets must be safely secured before play begins.

3.3 Match ball

- A regulation Size 5 football shall be used.
- The referee or competition officials may reject a ball that is damaged, unsafe or unsuitable for play.

SAFETY FIRST

The organiser and referee may delay or suspend play if the pitch, goals or equipment create an unsafe playing environment.

4. Teams, Squad Registration & Substitutions

4.1 Matchday numbers

- A team fields seven players when at full strength: one goalkeeper and six outfield players.
- A side must have at least five eligible players available to begin or continue a match.
- If a team falls below five players, the referee may stop the match, and the competition committee may apply the relevant forfeit provisions.

4.2 Squad limit

- A maximum of eleven players may be listed for a team's matchday squad.
- Only players recorded on the official matchday list may take part.

4.3 Rolling substitutions

- Substitutions are rolling, allowing players to leave and return during the match.
- A team may have no more than three substitutes available at the same time.
- Players entering or leaving the field must do so in accordance with the referee's instructions and without gaining an unfair advantage.
- A player who has been sent off cannot be replaced for the purpose of restoring the team's full playing strength.

4.4 No emergency additions

- A player cannot be added to the matchday squad because another registered player is injured, absent or unavailable.
- Managers, coaches and other team officials cannot enter the field as players.

5. Player Eligibility & Premier Player Classification

CORE ELIGIBILITY REQUIREMENT

Each squad must contain at least eight non-Premier players and may contain no more than three Premier Players.

5.1 Who may play

- Only players who have been properly registered for the competition may participate.
- Team officials, including managers and coaches, are not eligible to take a player's place.

5.2 Premier Player definition

- For this tournament, a Premier Player is any player who has featured in **five or more** official matches in the Darwin Men's Premier League 2026, including Australia Cup matches.

5.3 The three-player ceiling

- A team may list no more than three Premier Players in its eleven-player matchday squad.
- The eight-player non-Premier minimum applies to the squad, not merely to the players on the field.

5.4 Responsibility of teams

- Each team is responsible for checking the eligibility of its players before submitting a matchday squad.
- A team may be asked to provide eligibility information to the competition committee.

5.5 Consequences of an ineligible player

- If an ineligible player participates, the match may be recorded as a 3–0 loss against the offending team.
- The competition committee may impose additional disciplinary measures depending on the circumstances.

IMPORTANT

Eligibility is based on the registered matchday squad. Removing a Premier Player from the field does not cure a squad that exceeds the permitted Premier Player limit.

6. Kit, Equipment & Match Officials

6.1 Player equipment

- Players must wear suitable football clothing and properly fitted shin guards.
- Jewellery or other items considered dangerous by the referee must be removed.
- Teams should wear matching or clearly identifiable colours.

6.2 Colour clash

- If the referee determines that team colours cannot be clearly distinguished, a coin toss will decide which team changes or wears bibs.

6.3 Referee

- The referee is responsible for controlling the match and applying the competition rules.
- The referee may stop, delay or abandon play where required for safety, misconduct or other legitimate match-control reasons.
- Decisions made by the referee during the match are final, subject to any competition process specifically provided in this rulebook.

7. Match Timing & Starting the Game

7.1 Match duration

- League matches consist of two 10-minute halves, giving a scheduled playing time of 20 minutes.
- Final matches consist of two 15-minute halves, giving a scheduled playing time of 30 minutes.
- The referee controls the official match clock and determines stoppages where appropriate.

7.2 Kick-off

- The match begins from the centre mark after the referee signals for play to start.

- The team winning the pre-match choice determines the relevant kick-off option in accordance with the referee's direction.
- After a goal, the team that conceded restarts play from the centre.

7.3 Half-time and change of ends

- Teams change ends at half-time unless the organiser or referee directs otherwise for venue or safety reasons.

8. Ball Status, Scoring & Restarts

8.1 Ball in play

- The ball remains in play unless the whole of the ball has crossed a touchline or goal line, or the referee has stopped playing.

8.2 Goal

- A goal counts only when the entire ball passes over the goal line between the goalposts and beneath the crossbar, provided no infringement has occurred.

8.3 No offside

- **NO OFFSIDE**
The Grace Dashain Cup does not use an offside rule. Players may position themselves beyond the last defender, subject to the normal requirements of fair play and other offences.

8.4 Throw-ins

- When the ball completely crosses a touchline, the opposing team restarts play with a throw-in.
- The throw-in is taken from approximately the point where the ball left the field, as directed by the referee.

8.5 Goal kicks

- When the attacking team last touches the ball before it crosses the defending team's goal line without a goal being scored, play restarts with a goal kick.

8.6 Corner kicks

- A corner is awarded when the defending team last touches the ball before it crosses its own goal line and no goal is scored.
- The ball is placed within the appropriate corner area before the kick is taken.

9. Fouls, Free Kicks & Penalty Kicks

9.1 Fouls

- The referee may award a free kick for offences such as kicking, attempting to kick, tripping, pushing, holding, charging unfairly or deliberately handling the ball.
- The referee may also penalise reckless, dangerous or unsporting challenges even where the specific action is not listed.

9.2 Slide tackles

- **SLIDE TACKLES ARE NOT PERMITTED**
A player must not make a sliding tackle. The referee may penalise a slide tackle regardless of whether contact with an opponent occurs.

9.3 Free-kick procedure

- Free kicks are normally taken from the location of the infringement, unless the referee requires another position under these regulations.
- Opponents must move back to the distance directed by the referee.
- Unless the referee determines that a different restart applies, free kicks in this competition are indirect.

9.4 Penalty kicks

- A penalty is awarded when an offence punishable by a direct free kick occurs inside the offending team's penalty area.
- The kick is taken from the designated penalty mark.
- All players other than the kicker and goalkeeper must remain in the positions directed by the referee.
- The goalkeeper must remain on the goal line until the kick is taken, subject to the referee's instructions.

10. Goalkeeper Regulations

10.1 Handling area

- The goalkeeper may use the hands within their own penalty area, except where a specific restriction in this section applies.

10.2 Deliberate teammate pass

- A goalkeeper must not pick up or handle a ball deliberately kicked to them by a teammate.
- The goalkeeper may play such a ball with the feet.
- If the goalkeeper handles a deliberate back-pass, the opposing team receives an indirect free kick from the place of the infringement, subject to the referee's direction.

10.3 Distribution after catching

- After taking possession with the hands, the goalkeeper must not kick the ball directly beyond the halfway line using a conventional kick.
- A drop-kick is permitted and may travel beyond halfway.
- The goalkeeper may also throw, roll, bounce or play the ball short to a teammate.
- A breach of the direct-kick distribution restriction results in an indirect free kick for the opposition from the halfway line.

10.4 Fair distribution

- The goalkeeper must release the ball without deliberately delaying the match. The referee may take action where distribution is used to waste time.

11. Disciplinary Code

11.1 Yellow card — temporary dismissal

- A player receiving a yellow card under the tournament's temporary-dismissal system leaves the field for five minutes.
- During the temporary dismissal, the player's team plays with one fewer player.
- The player may return only after the five-minute period has elapsed and the referee authorises the return.
- The referee may record repeated misconduct and may escalate disciplinary action where appropriate.

11.2 Red card — sending-off

- A player shown a red card is removed from the match and cannot return.
- The team continues the match with one fewer player.

- A red-carded player receives an automatic one-match suspension, subject to any additional sanction imposed by the competition committee.

11.3 Fighting and violent conduct

- **ZERO TOLERANCE**
Fighting, physical confrontation or violent conduct is treated as a serious tournament offence. The priority is player safety and maintaining a respectful competition environment.
- Any player involved in fighting or violent physical conduct may be immediately sent off by the referee.
- The incident will be referred to the competition committee.
- Players involved in a fight or physical confrontation are automatically suspended for the remainder of the tournament.
- No appeal is available against the automatic tournament suspension arising from fighting or physical confrontation.
- The affected team must continue with the players remaining after the dismissal.
- The competition committee may impose further sanctions where necessary.

11.4 Team responsibility

- Teams are expected to control the behaviour of their players and officials and to cooperate with match officials.
- Abusive, threatening or intimidating behaviour towards referees, opponents, organisers or venue staff may lead to further disciplinary action.

12. Corners, Throw-Ins & General Playing Procedures

12.1 Restarts

- All restarts must be taken promptly and from the location directed by the referee.
- The referee may require a restart to be retaken where the procedure has not been correctly followed.

12.2 Fair play

- Players must not deliberately distract, obstruct or unfairly delay an opponent taking a restart.
- The referee may add disciplinary action for repeated time-wasting or unsporting conduct.

12.3 Match control

- Players and team officials must follow reasonable instructions from the referee and competition officials.
- Only authorised team personnel may occupy the designated team area.

13. Match Interruptions & Rescheduling

13.1 Reasons for interruption

- A match may be suspended or stopped because of severe weather, lighting failure, unsafe playing conditions, venue or facility problems, or another serious technical issue.
- The referee may stop play immediately where player safety is at risk.

13.2 Restarting an interrupted match

- Where possible, an interrupted match will be completed or replayed on the next suitable date determined by the competition committee.
- The committee will determine the replacement date, time and venue after considering venue availability, safety and competition scheduling.
- Teams must comply with the committee's rescheduling decision.

14. Late Arrival, Forfeits & Rule Breaches

14.1 Arrival requirement

- Teams must be at the venue, ready to play and able to provide their matchday squad at the scheduled kick-off time.
- A five-minute grace period applies after the scheduled kick-off.
- If a team has not arrived or cannot field the required playable team within the grace period, the match may be declared a forfeit.

14.2 Forfeit result

- A forfeited match is recorded as a 3–0 victory for the opposing team.
- The competition committee may impose additional consequences where the circumstances justify them.

14.3 Other breaches

- A breach not specifically addressed elsewhere in this rulebook may be dealt with by the competition committee.
- Unless a different sanction is expressly provided, a serious competition breach may result in a 3–0 forfeit and/or additional disciplinary action.
- The severity of any additional sanction may take into account intent, repeat behaviour, sporting impact and cooperation with organisers.

15. Competition Integrity & Dispute Handling

15.1 Integrity of the tournament

- Every team is responsible for submitting accurate player and registration information.
- Teams must not deliberately conceal player eligibility information or use an unregistered player.
- Attempts to manipulate results, player status or competition administration may be referred to the competition committee for sanction.

15.2 Match-day concerns

- Concerns about a player's eligibility or a serious rule breach should be raised with the competition officials as soon as reasonably possible.
- The referee controls decisions during the match; the competition committee handles administrative and disciplinary matters outside the referee's immediate match-control role.

15.3 Final authority

- The competition committee's determination on competition administration and disciplinary matters is final and binding unless the organisers expressly provide another review process.
- **RESPECT THE GAME**
The tournament is intended to be competitive without losing its community spirit. Respect for opponents, referees, volunteers and spectators is an essential part of participation.

16. Team Acknowledgement & Declaration

By submitting the registration and selecting the applicable acceptance option, the team representative confirms that the team has received and reviewed the Official Grace Dashain Cup 7-a-side Rulebook. The representative agrees that all players and team officials will comply with the competition requirements and accept the authority of the match officials and competition committee within the scope of these regulations.

The representative further acknowledges that breaches of the rulebook may lead to appropriate action, including a warning, temporary dismissal, sending-off, suspension, match forfeiture, tournament removal or other sanctions determined under the competition regulations.

2nd GRACE DASHAIN CUP

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